# Making a Living

Stuart Halloway
stuarthalloway.com

# make, v.

| RANK | WORD |
| --- | --- |
| 58 | make |

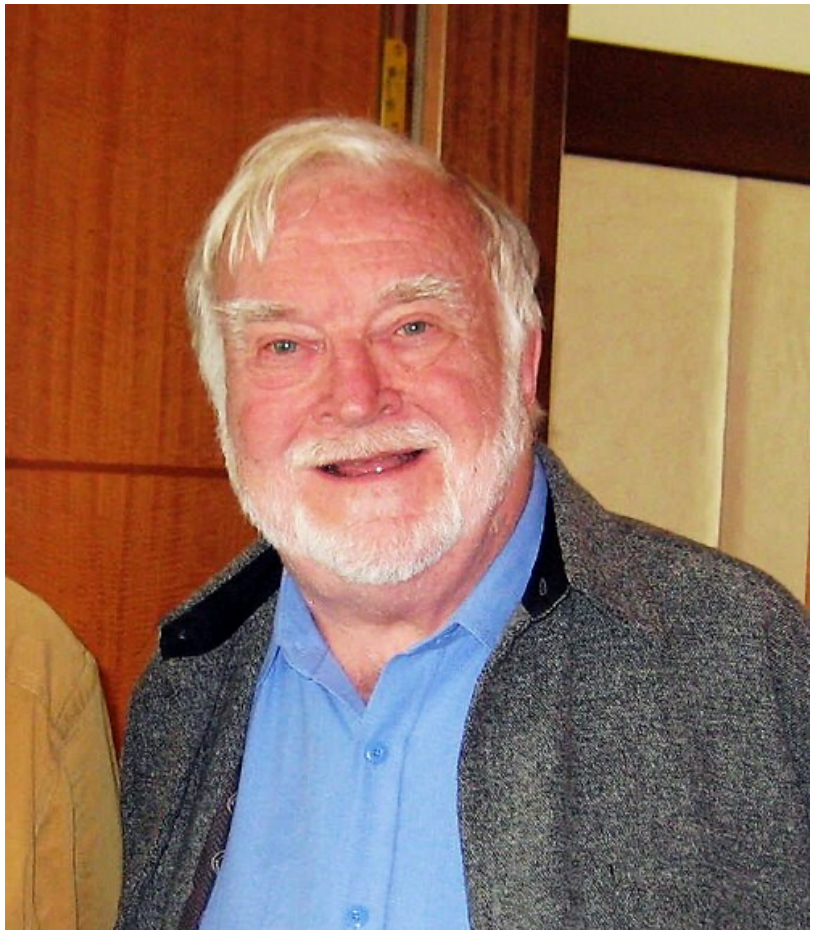
| RANK | WORD |
| --- | --- |
| 774 | simple |

https://frequencylist.com/

# flow

- absorption
- effortless control
- changed experience of time
- "in the zone"

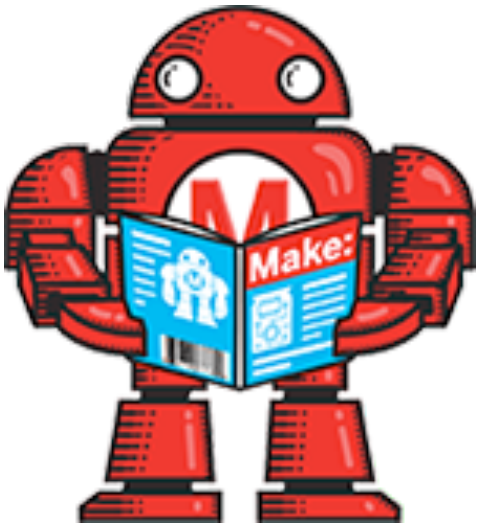
- autotelicity



https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mihaly_Csikszentmihalyi

# community

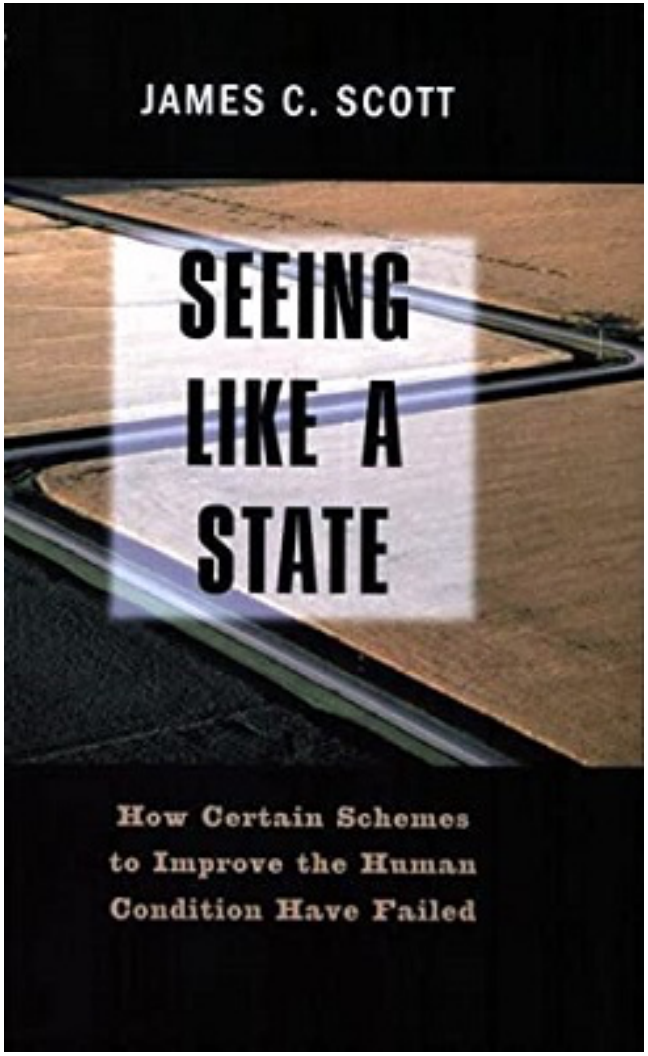
"The term “maker” changed everything... The maker movement ... celebrates the power of human ingenuity and reminds us that we can all create, connect, learn, and share while doing what we love."




https://make.co/maker-movement/

# metis, n.

"a wide array of practical skills and acquired intelligence in responding to a constantly changing natural and human environment"




https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Seeing_Like_a_State

How to draw an owl

1.



2.

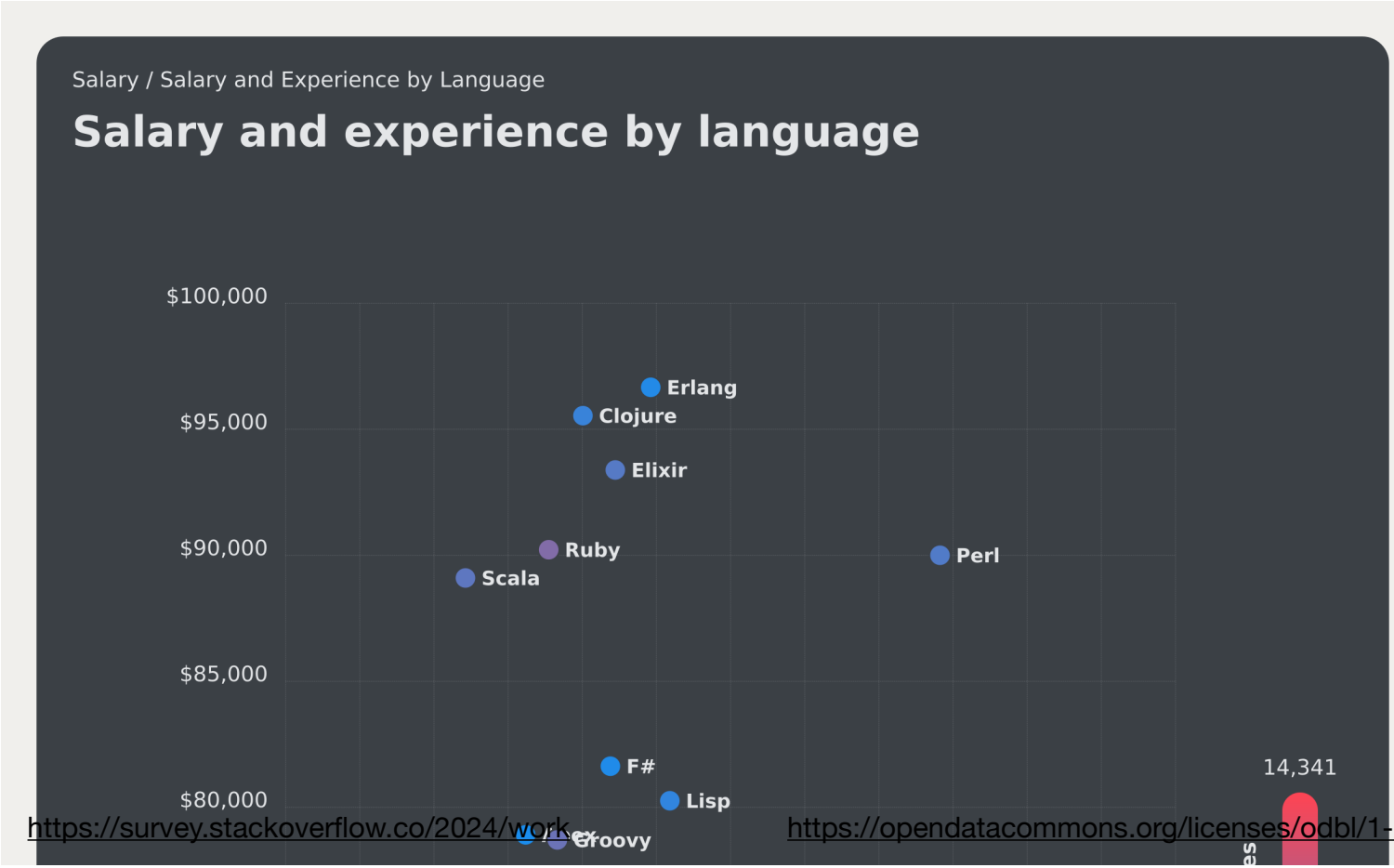


1. Draw some circles

2. Draw the rest of the fucking owl

https://www.reddit.com/r/funny/comments/eccj2/how_to_draw_an_owl/

# making a living...




https://survey.stackoverflow.co/2024/work

https://opendatacommons.org/licenses/odbl/1-0/

# ... by making software

1. idea
2. ????
3. profit!

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Gnomes_(South_Park)

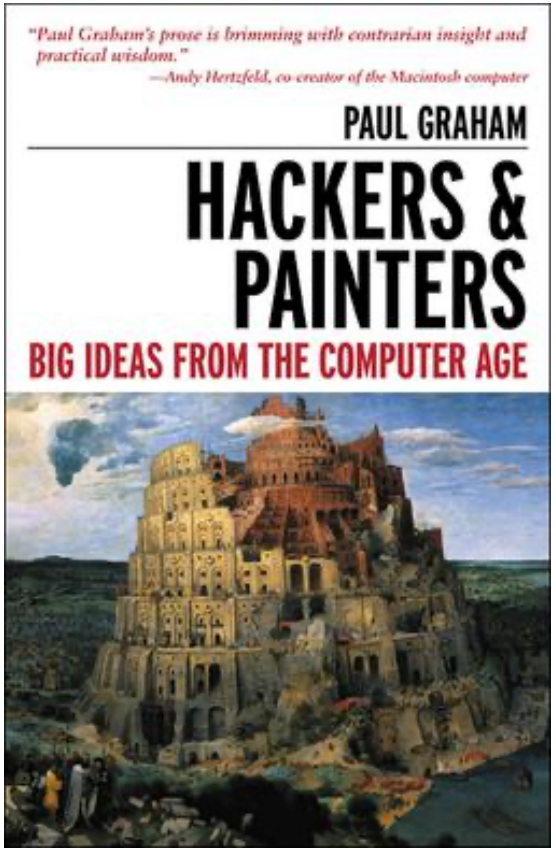
# ???? = programming

1. idea
2. ????
3. profit!

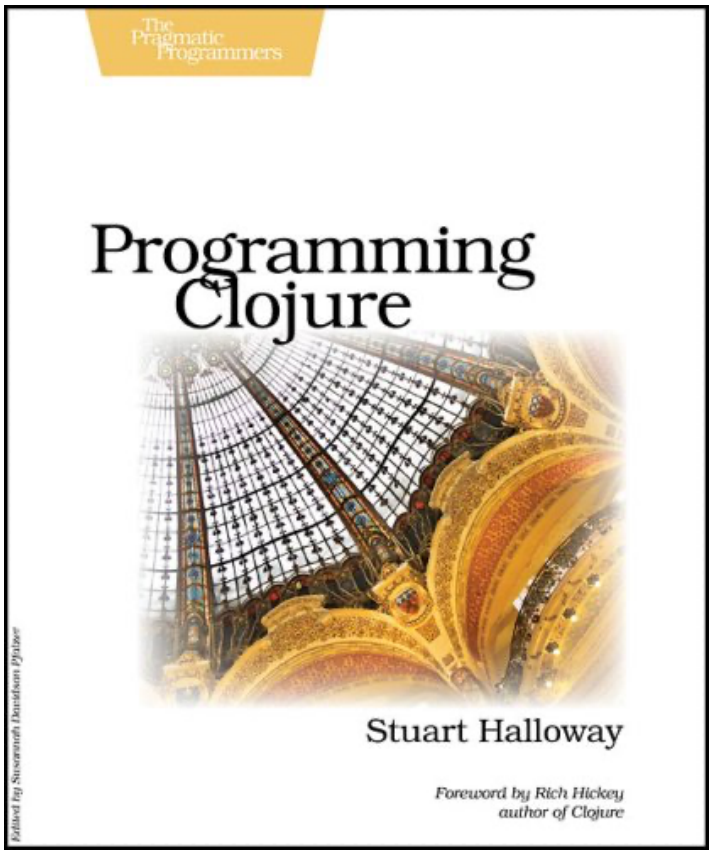


Programmer at work

# metaprogramming!




https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hackers_&_Painters




https://pragprog.com/titles/shcloj4/programming-clojure-fourth-edition/

# Stochastic Language Model Metaprogramming

# making software

1. idea
2. stochastic language model metaprogramming
3. profit!

# making software

1. idea
2. SLMMing
3. profit!



"imagine every person on earth with a second mind beyond their own ...

[that] solves all the problems it can until the human part, the wanting and the dreaming, is all that’s left"



https://x.com/alexandr_wang/article/2103551714536439951

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Alexandr_Wang

# Vauntingly Ignoring Basic Engineering

"imagine every person on earth with a second mind beyond their own ...

[that] solves all the problems it can until the human part, the wanting and the dreaming, is all that’s left"



https://x.com/alexandr_wang/article/2103551714536439951

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Alexandr_Wang

# Vauntingly Ignoring Basically Everything

# Vauntingly Ignoring Basic Engineering

VIBEing

# Ghâshûrz thrakatulûk

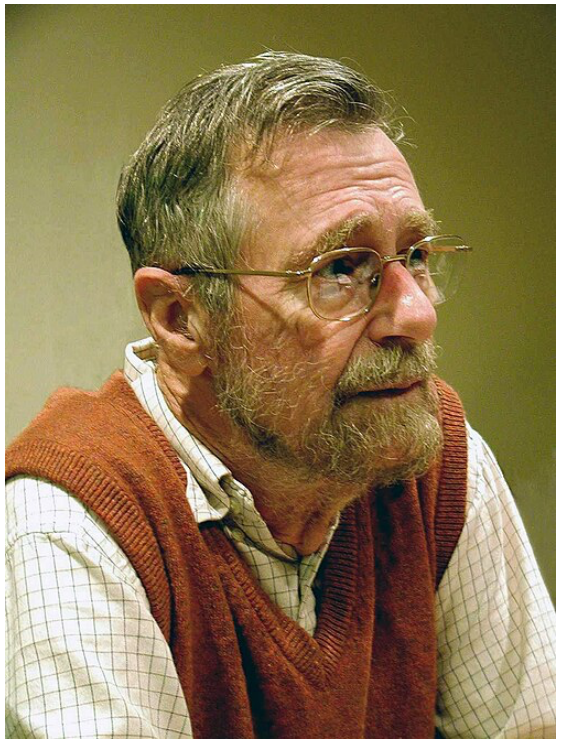
https://www.polytranslator.com/black-speech/

# Artificial Intelligence

# does it work?

# natural language programming?

"...discourage those believers in natural language programming that lack the technical insight needed to predict its failure."



https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Edsger_W._Dijkstra

https://www.cs.utexas.edu/~EWD/transcriptions/EWD06xx/EWD667.html

# coding is the hard part?

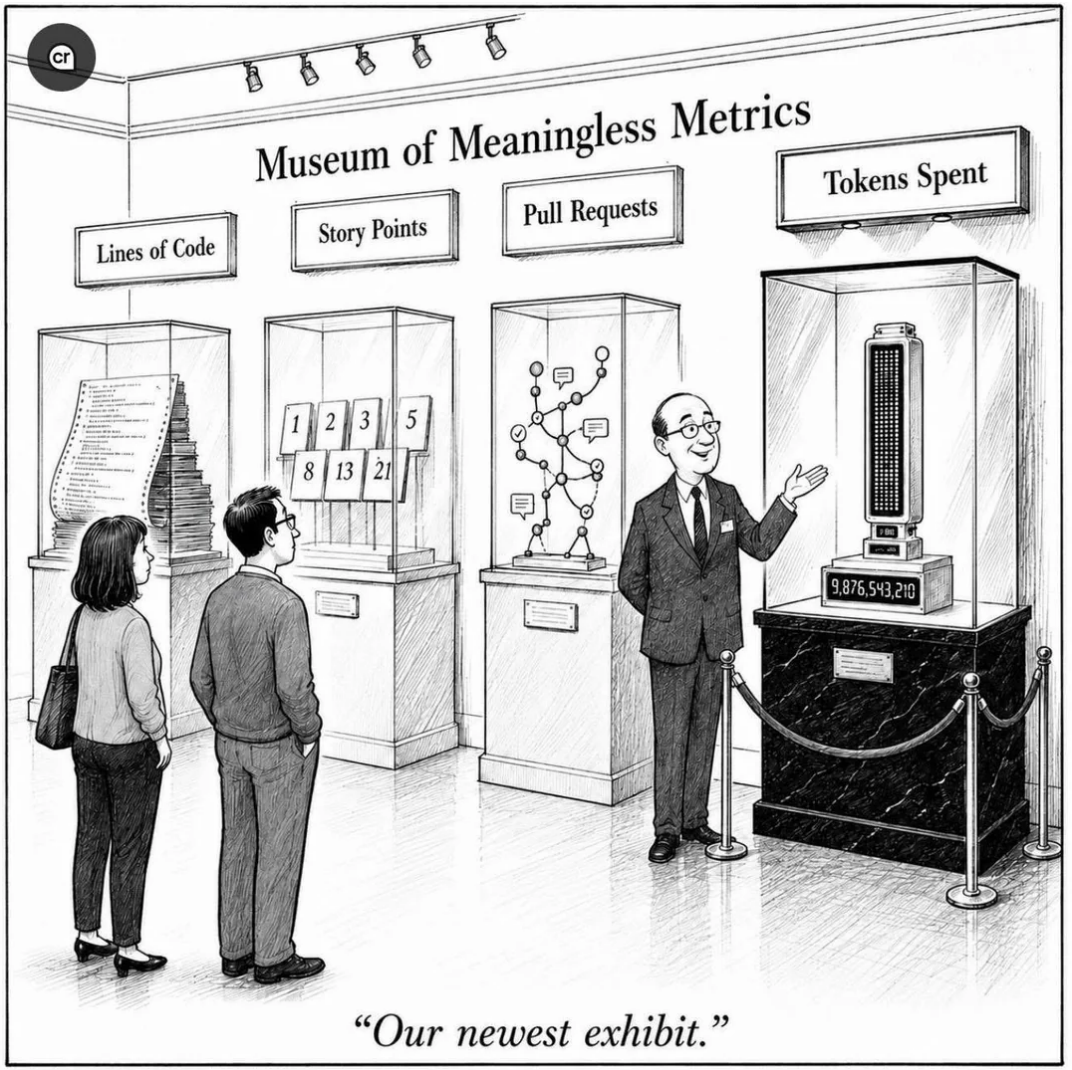
"The hard thing about building software is deciding what to say, not saying it. No facilitation of expression can give more than marginal gains."

The Mythical Man-Month
Essays on Software Engineering Anniversary Edition
p.191



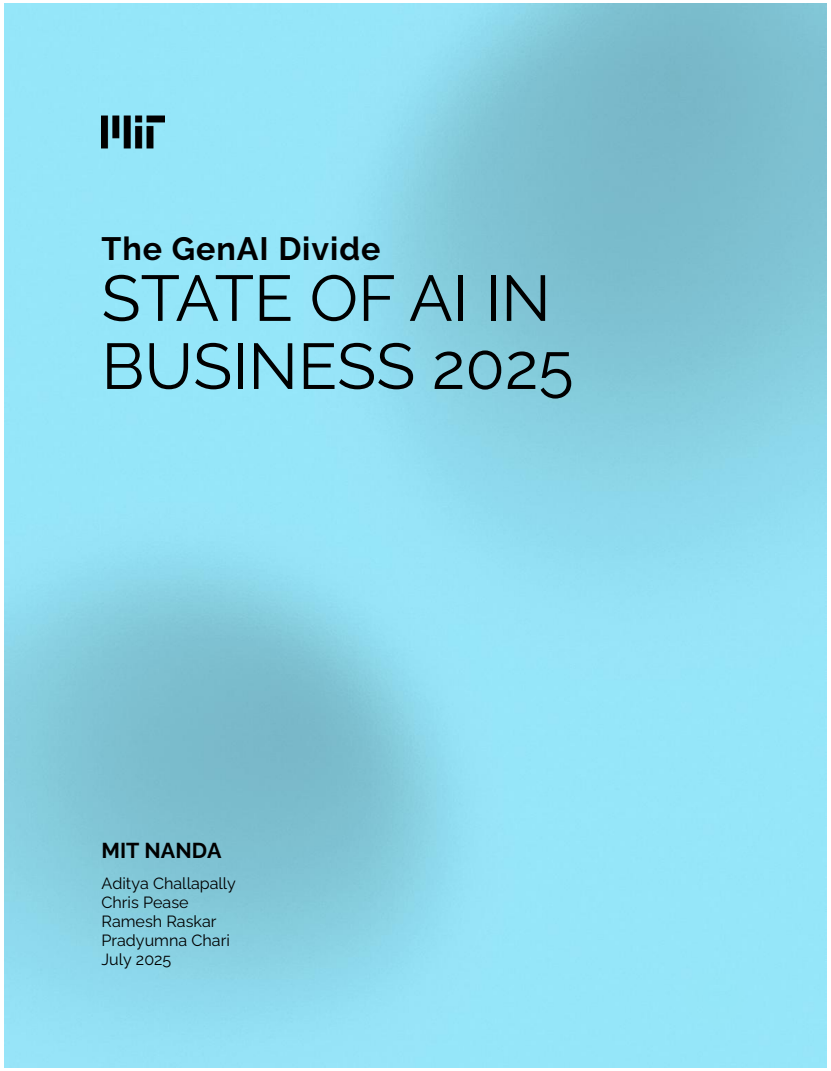
https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Fred_Brooks

# productivity "studies" are crap




https://markcarrigan.net/wp-content/uploads/2026/06/image-1.png

"Despite $30–40 billion in enterprise investment into GenAI, this report uncovers a surprising result in that 95% of organizations are getting zero return"




https://mlq.ai/media/quarterly_decks/v0.1_State_of_AI_in_Business_2025_Report.pdf

# Slopfree Software Index

A list of software that has taken steps to **reject** AI in its development processes.

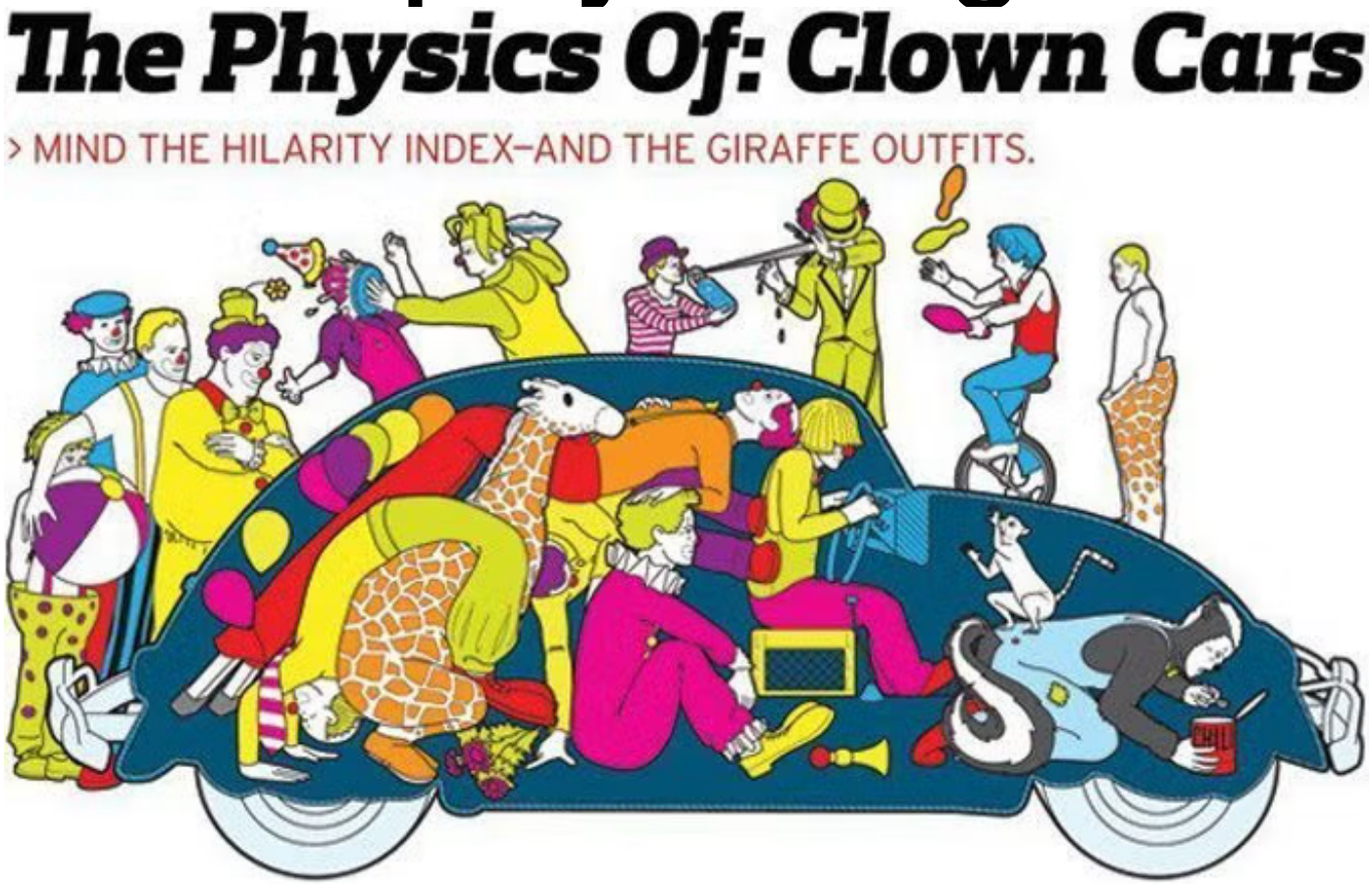
There's been a lot of news about prominent open-source projects increasingly using LLMs. But this only shows one side of the story - we don't see all the software that rejects AI contributions and continues to be human-made.

### Languages

- Clojure - https://clojure.org/dev/contributor_agreement#_no_generated_code
- Fennel - https://git.sr.ht/~technomancy/fennel/tree/main/item/CONTRIBUTING.md#contribution-transparency
- Idris - https://github.com/idris-lang/Idris2/blob/main/CONTRIBUTING.md#things-we-will-not-accept (Has the Claude banner due to a single Claude commit that occurred before this policy took effect. After that commit was made, the project changed their contributing guidelines to block LLM code.)
- Typst - https://github.com/typst/typst/blob/main/CONTRIBUTING.md
- Zig - https://ziglang.org/code-of-conduct/#strict-no-llm-no-ai-policy

https://codeberg.org/brib/slopfree-software-index/src/branch/main/README.md

# forward deployed engineers




https://www.caranddriver.com/features/a15125743/the-physics-of-clown-cars-feature/

# where to put AI on the radar?

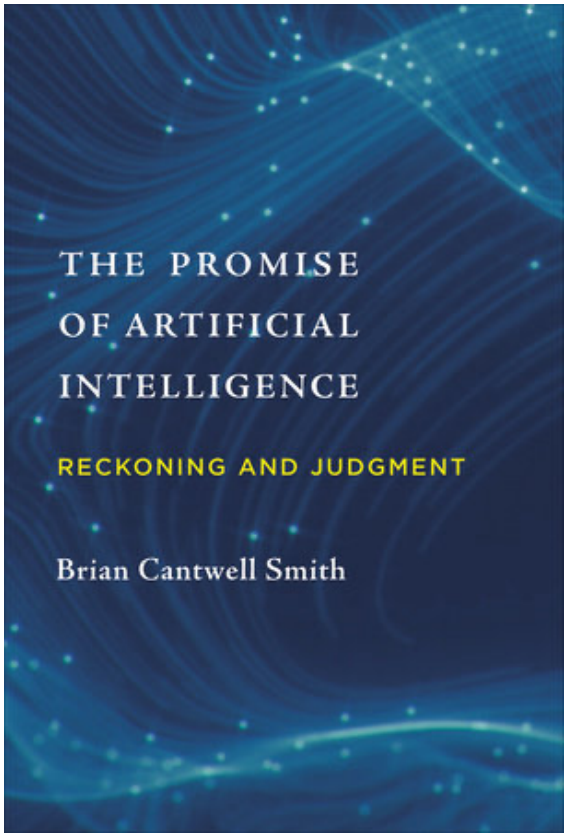
- caution
- assess
- trial
- adopt

# where to put AI on the radar?

- caution
- assess
- trial
- adopt
- **bet the global economy**

# reckoning without judgment

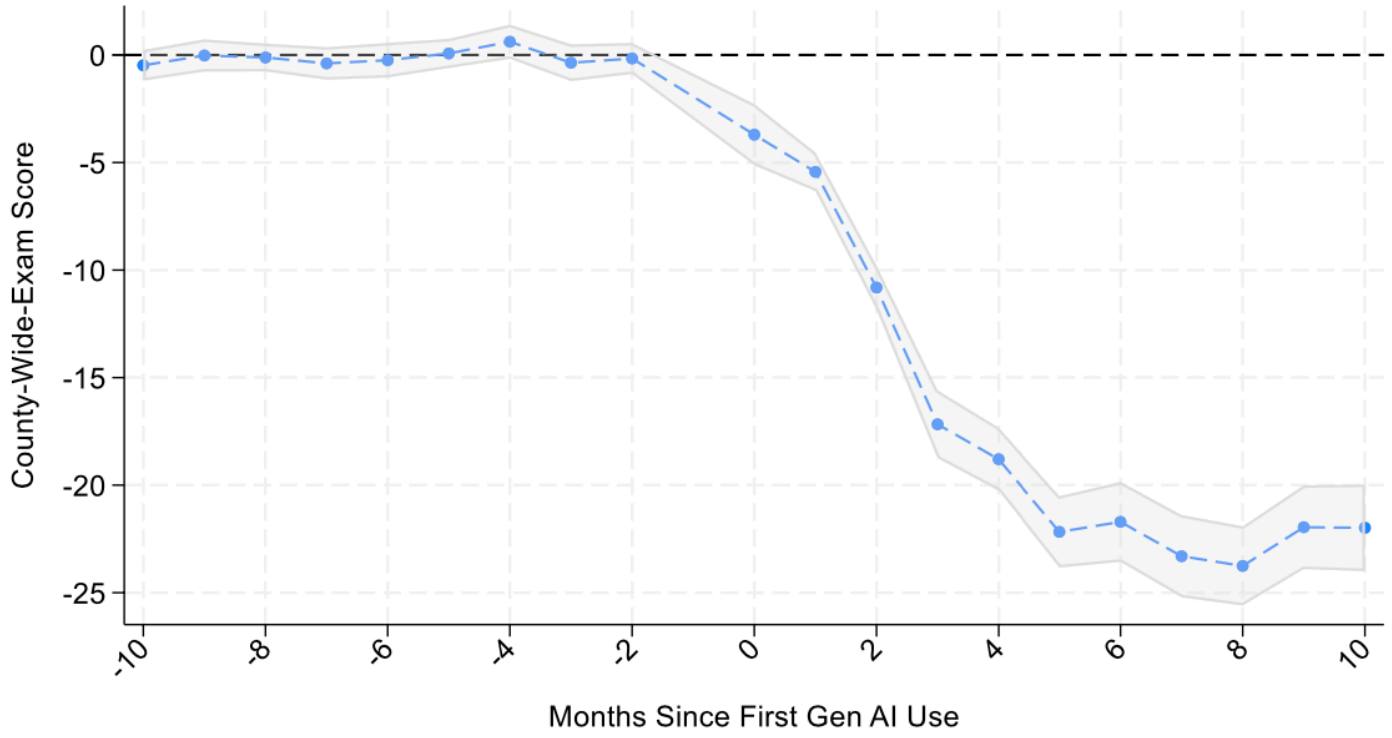
"terrified that we will rely on reckoning where judgment is needed"




https://direct.mit.edu/books/book/4564/The-Promise-of-Artificial-IntelligenceReckoning

# people are getting dumber

Figure A7. Effects on County-wide Exams by Event Time



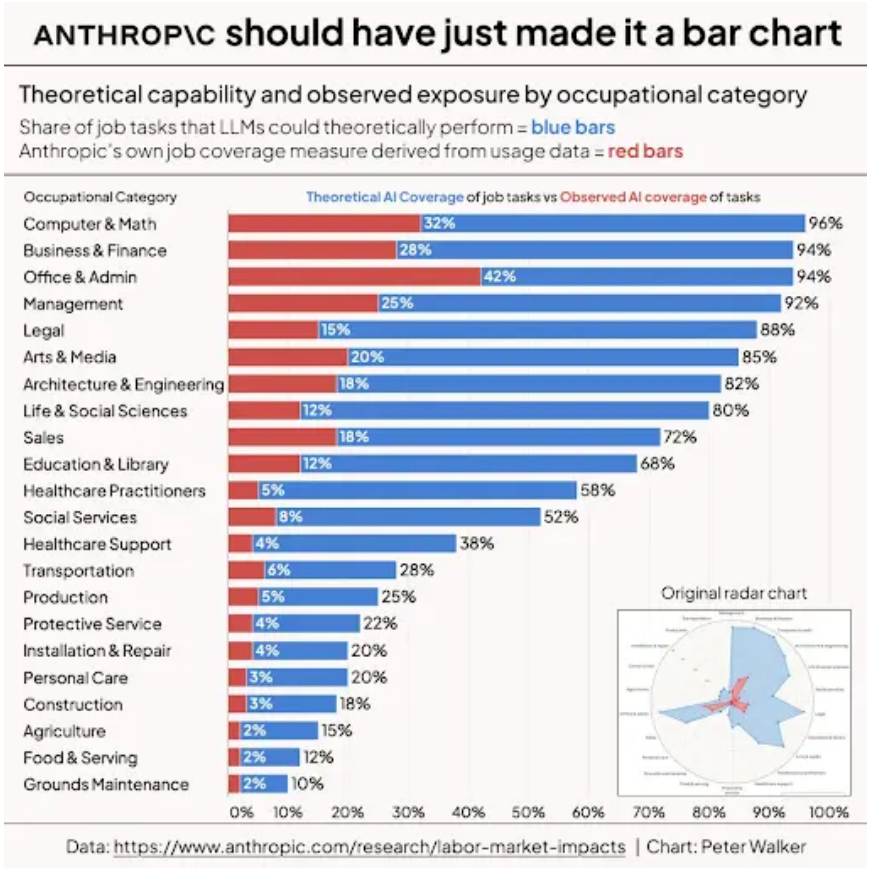

https://papers.ssrn.com/sol3/papers.cfm?abstract_id=6868618

# asking better questions

- what is "it"?
- why is "it" happening?
- cui bono?

# "it" is *automation*, not AI

Anthropic CEO warns AI could eliminate half of all entry-level white-collar jobs




https://fortune.com/2025/05/28/anthropic-ceo-warning-ai-job-loss/

https://fortune.com/2026/03/06/ai-job-losses-report-anthropic-research-great-recession-for-white-collar-workers/

# "why" is *because they think they can*

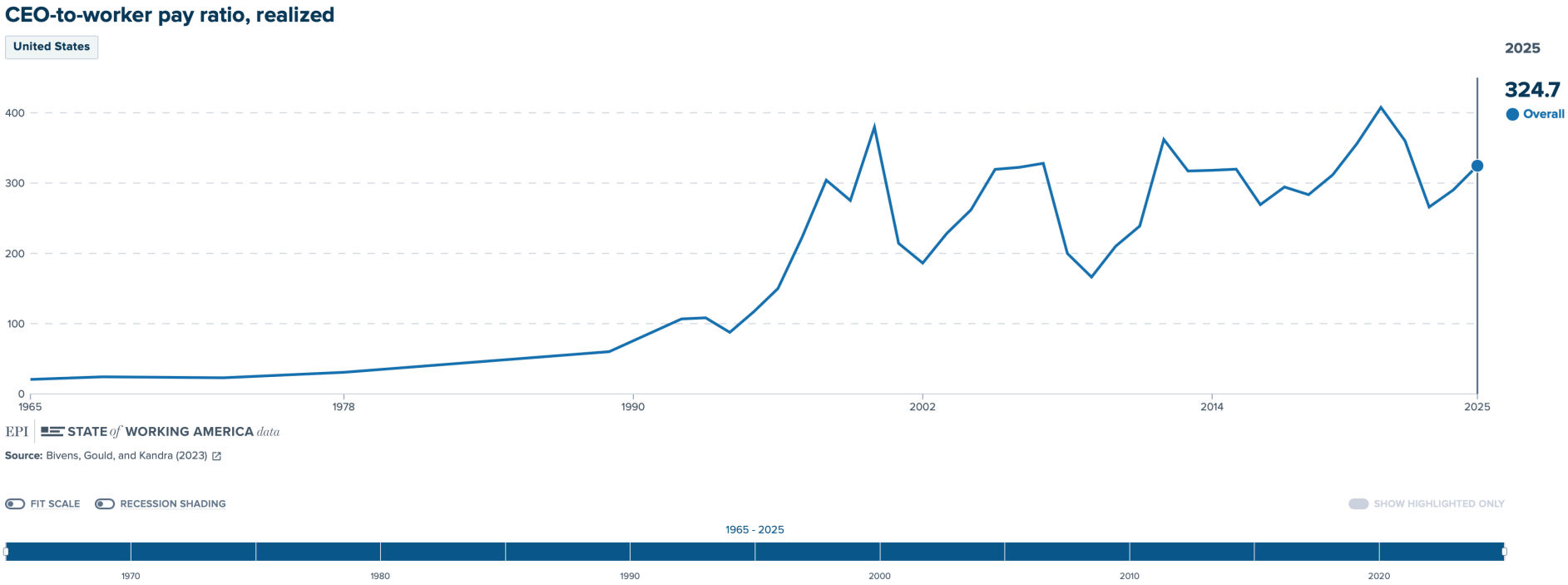






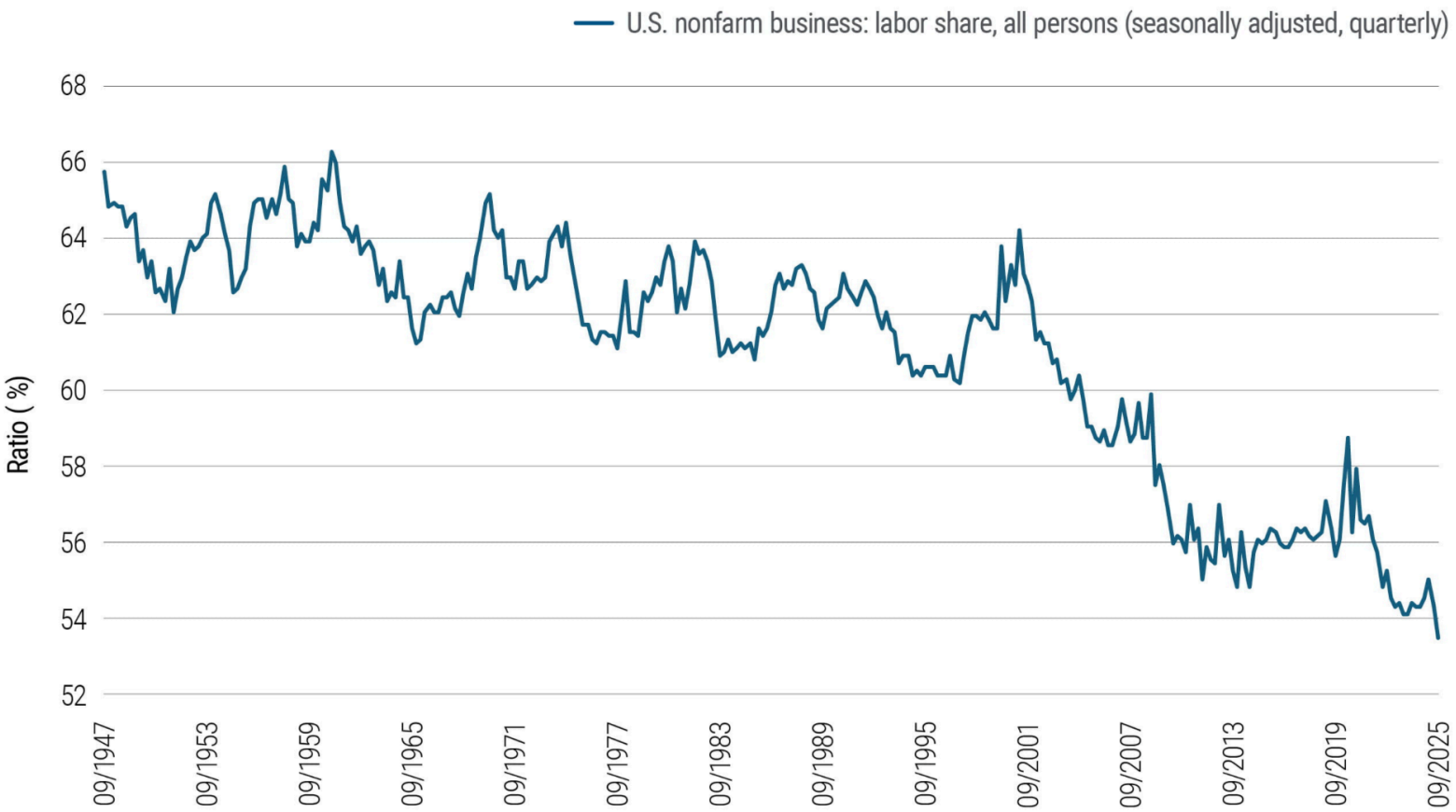
https://www.vice.com/en/article/amazon-denies-workers-pee-in-bottles-here-are-the-pee-bottles/
https://www.vice.com/en/article/selling-bottles-of-amazon-drivers-pee/

# cui bono: *the ultra-rich(-er)*




https://data.epi.org/wage_gaps/ceo_pay_ratio/line/year/national/ceo_worker_realized/overall?timeStart=1965-01-01&timeEnd=2025-01-01&dateString=2025-01-01&highlightedLines=overall

# labor share of income




Source: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS), Haver Analytics as of Q3 2025

https://www.pimco.com/us/en/insights/why-us-productivity-gains-no-longer-reach-workers

"combine the banality of evil with an internet-connected device and a federal law that criminalizes doing anything with the device that the manufacturer dislikes"



https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Enshittification

# peak regulatory capture



https://www.thesouthafrican.com/news/tech-billionaires-take-centre-stage-at-donald-trump-inauguration-photo-elon-musk-jeff-bezos-mark-zuckerberg/

# too cool for oversight

“Any regulatory agency that has to approve AI product releases will become like a DMV for AI, where new models get stuck in a long queue waiting for approval...

[AI is] just too dynamic and fast-moving for that type of approach"



https://www.cnet.com/tech/services-and-software/g20-innovation-ministerial-ai-regulation-us-news/

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/David_Sacks



# insist on AI disclosure

## Table: Suggested Language for Disclosing Generative AI Use in Scientific Work

| Content affected | +Action taken | +AI tool | +Purpose of AI use | +Human oversight |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| • Throughout this work...<br>• Existing text in this manuscript...<br>• Portions of this | • ...authors used...<br>• ...was reviewed...<br>• ...was edited...<br>• ...were | • ...no AI tools...<br>• ...using Name of AI tool [model/version, if available] | • ...to propose, perform, or review any content;<br>• ...for language refinement;<br>• ...to draft parts of the paper, summarize, paraphrase, | • to the best of our knowledge.<br>• authors reviewed and approved all edits. |

https://www.cdc.gov/ai/resources/considerations-for-generative-ai-use-in-scientific-work.html

**In preparing this talk, I avoided intentional use of AI.**
**I created and revised the content myself.**
**I disabled AI summaries in my search engine and read the referenced materials directly.**

*Stuart Halloway*

# IT'S RUDE TO SHOW AI OUTPUT TO PEOPLE

For the longest time, writing was more expensive than reading. If you encountered a body of written text, you could be sure that at the very least, a human spent *some* time writing it down. The **text used to have an innate proof-of-thought**, a basic token of humanity.

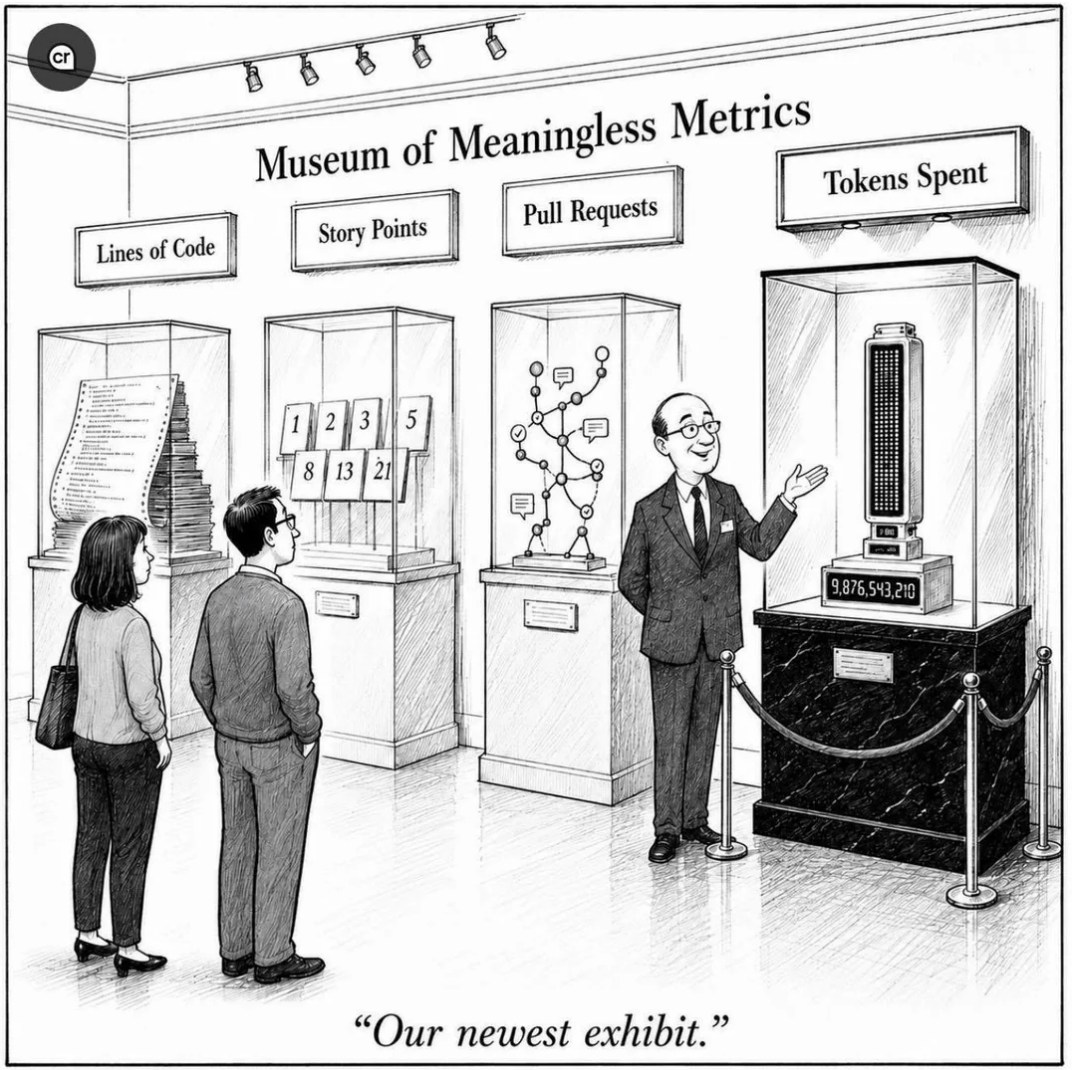
...

I think that realistically, our main weapon in this war is AI etiquette.



https://distantprovince.by/posts/its-rude-to-show-ai-output-to-people/

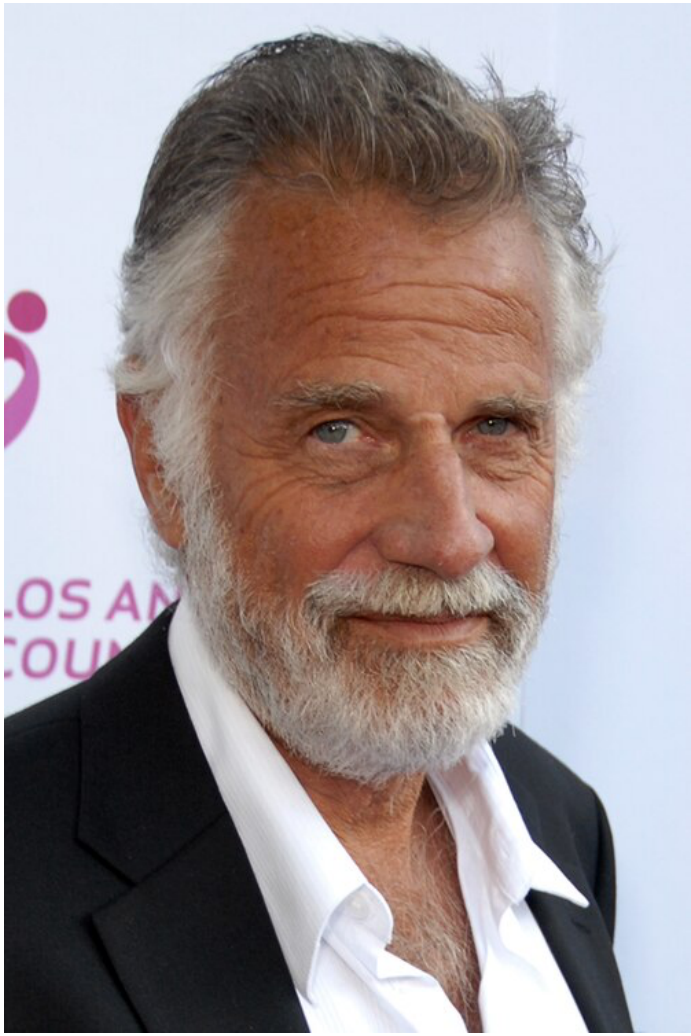
productivity "studies" are ***still*** crap




https://markcarrigan.net/wp-content/uploads/2026/06/image-1.png

# deplatformize LLMs

I don't always run agents.
But when I do, I prefer my own hardware.



https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_Most_Interesting_Man_in_the_World

# keep the friction

NYC recently announced a one-year ban on forklifts and jetpacks in elementary school physical education classes



https://apnews.com/article/zohran-mamdani-ai-ban-nyc-schools-647f6a968eea0399521b7934418b1aff

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Zohran_Mamdani

# keep the friction

NYC recently announced a one-year ban on generative AI in elementary school



https://apnews.com/article/zohran-mamdani-ai-ban-nyc-schools-647f6a968eea0399521b7934418b1aff

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Zohran_Mamdani

# automate for quality

"When labor drives automation, it’s usually in service to making the product better, and when capital drives automation, it’s usually in service to making more of the product"



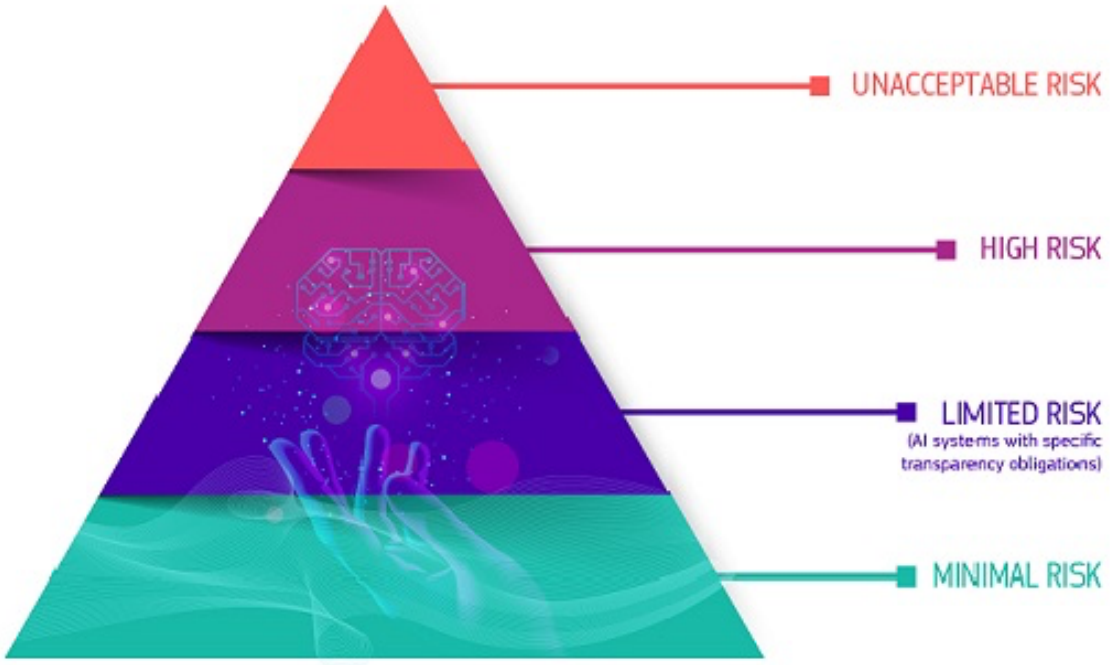
https://www.democracynow.org/2026/6/25/reverse_centaur_doctorow

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cory_Doctorow

# collective action

- group peer pressure at all scales
- unionization
- politics and policy
- enforce existing rules

# hold companies accountable




https://digital-strategy.ec.europa.eu/en/policies/regulatory-framework-ai#1720699867912-0

# stay on topic

- LLMs are automation
  - directed by people for economic and political ends
  - not intelligent
  - have no agency
  - take no responsibility

# will
# AI
# kill us all?

will
~~AI~~ automation
kill us all?

will oligarchs
and their automation schemes
kill us all?

# are we* responsible enough to handle AGI?



# everything still matters

- programming languages
- libraries
- communities

- hard problems are still hard
- friction still builds expertise

# programming remains a human activity

"The quality of software is measured by a number of totally incompatible criteria, which must be carefully balanced in the design and implementation of every program"



https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Tony_Hoare

# critical thinking still *dominates*

- COVID
- social media
- cognitive surrender to AI

